

Marrakech — 20 Essential Destinations

Knowledge Base for RAG Integration

Comprehensive reference document covering history, location, opening hours, practical tips, and RAG indexing tags for each site.

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1. Jemaa el-Fna ساحة جامع الفناء

Public Square · Square · UNESCO · Nightlife · Food

Location	Centre of the Medina, adjacent to the entrance of the souks
Historical Period	Founded 11th century (Almoravid dynasty)
Opening Hours	Open 24 hours. Most vibrant at sunset (18:00–22:00)
Entrance Fee	Free
Nearest Souk	Souk Semmarine (2 min walk north)

Description

The beating heart of Marrakech and a UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage site. By day the square is populated by orange juice vendors, Gnawa musicians, henna artists, acrobats, and snake charmers. As the sun sets, the atmosphere transforms dramatically: hundreds of food stalls materialise, storytellers (halqa) draw circles of listeners, and the air fills with smoke and spice. The square has been the social centre of the city for nearly a thousand years and remains one of the most captivating urban spaces in the world.

Practical Tips

- Arrive at sunset for the most spectacular atmosphere
- Freshly squeezed orange juice costs around 4–5 MAD per glass
- Performers expect tips — agree on a price before posing for photos
- Pickpockets are active; keep bags zipped and in front of you

RAG Index Tags

Jemaa el-Fna | Djemaa el-Fna | main square | food stalls | snake charmers | night market | Marrakech centre

2. Koutoubia Mosque جامع الكتبية

Religious Monument · Mosque · Almohad · 12th century · Landmark

Location	West of Jemaa el-Fna, Koutoubia district
Historical Period	1147–1158 AD under Almohad sultan Abd al-Mumin
Opening Hours	Gardens open daily. Mosque interior: Muslims only
Entrance Fee	Gardens free
Nearest Souk	Souk Semmarine (5 min walk east)

Description

The largest mosque in Marrakech and one of the finest examples of Almohad architecture in the world. Its 70-metre minaret became the architectural template for two other iconic towers: the Giralda in Seville (Spain) and the Hassan Tower in Rabat. The name Koutoubia derives from the Arabic word for booksellers (kutubiyyin), as a market of manuscript sellers once surrounded it. The surrounding rose gardens are beautifully maintained and offer a peaceful retreat from the bustle of the medina. The minaret is illuminated at night.

Practical Tips

- Best photographs from the gardens at golden hour
- The minaret is visible from most of the medina — use it as a navigation landmark
- Non-Muslims may not enter the mosque itself

RAG Index Tags

Koutoubia | mosque | minaret | Almohad | Giralda | landmark | rose garden

3. Bahia Palace قصر الباهية

Historic Palace · Palace · 19th century · Architecture · Gardens

Location	Southern Medina, Riad Zitoun el-Jedid street
Historical Period	Built 1866–1900 by grand vizier Si Musa and his son Ba Ahmed
Opening Hours	Daily 09:00–17:00
Entrance Fee	70 MAD
Nearest Souk	Souk Cherratine (10 min walk north)

Description

Bahia Palace — meaning "brilliance" in Arabic — is one of the most opulent examples of Moroccan and Islamic architecture in Marrakech. It was constructed over several decades for grand vizier Si Musa and later expanded by his son Ba Ahmed to house his four wives and 24 concubines. The complex spans 8 hectares and includes 150 rooms arranged around a series of riad-style courtyards. Highlights include the grand courtyard shaded by orange and banana trees, a harem adorned with intricate zellij (mosaic tilework), hand-painted cedarwood ceilings, and carved plaster (stucco) in geometric and floral patterns. When the French protectorate was established in 1912, the Resident-General occupied the palace.

Practical Tips

- Visit early morning to avoid tour groups
- The painted wooden ceilings are the highlight — look up
- The complex is large; allow 1–1.5 hours

RAG Index Tags

Bahia Palace | palace | zellij | cedarwood ceilings | 19th century | grand vizier | riad courtyards

4. Saadian Tombs المقابر السعدية

Historic Necropolis · Tombs · Saadian dynasty · 16th century · UNESCO

Location	Kasbah district, adjacent to the Kasbah Mosque
Historical Period	Late 16th century under Sultan Ahmad al-Mansur (r. 1578–1603)
Opening Hours	Daily 09:00–17:00
Entrance Fee	70 MAD
Nearest Souk	Souk Semmarine (15 min walk north)

Description

The Saadian Tombs are a royal necropolis dating from the reign of Sultan Ahmad al-Mansur of the Saadian dynasty. They were sealed after the Saadians were supplanted by the Alaouite dynasty and remained hidden for over two centuries until rediscovered by a French aerial survey in 1917. The complex contains 66 graves arranged in three main chambers. The centrepiece is the Hall of Twelve Columns, which features twelve columns of Italian Carrara marble, intricate muqarnas plasterwork, and gilded cedar ceilings. The tombs of Sultan Ahmad al-Mansur and his family are among the most elaborately decorated in Morocco. The site is compact but extraordinarily detailed.

Practical Tips

- Arrive when it opens at 09:00 — the site is small and queues form quickly
- Photography is permitted
- Combine with a visit to El Badi Palace (5 min walk)

RAG Index Tags

Saadian Tombs | necropolis | Hall of Twelve Columns | Carrara marble | muqarnas | Kasbah | Saadian dynasty

5. El Badi Palace قصر البديع

Historic Ruins · Palace · Ruins · Saadian · 16th century · Views

Location	Kasbah district, near the Mellah
Historical Period	Built from 1578 by Sultan Ahmad al-Mansur
Opening Hours	Daily 09:00–17:00
Entrance Fee	70 MAD
Nearest Souk	Mellah market (5 min walk)

Description

El Badi Palace — "The Incomparable" — was built by Sultan Ahmad al-Mansur to celebrate his victory over the Portuguese at the Battle of the Three Kings (1578). At its zenith it was considered one of the most magnificent palaces in the world, decorated with gold, onyx, turquoise, and Italian marble said to have been traded weight-for-weight for sugar. After the Saadian dynasty fell, the Alaouite sultan Moulay Ismail stripped it of its materials to build his imperial capital in Meknes. Today El Badi is a picturesque ruin of sunken gardens, deep pools, and ramparts colonised by nesting white storks. The original cedarwood minbar (pulpit) from the Koutoubia Mosque is displayed in the on-site museum. The rampart walkways offer panoramic views over the medina.

Practical Tips

- Climb the ramparts for the best views of the city and Atlas Mountains
- The underground chambers (silos) are worth exploring
- White storks nest on the towers from February to August

RAG Index Tags

El Badi Palace | ruins | Saadian | storks | Koutoubia minbar | panoramic views | Battle of Three Kings

6. Majorelle Garden حديقة ماجوريل

Botanical Garden & Museum · Garden · YSL · Botanical · Art Deco · Museum

Location	Gueliz (Ville Nouvelle), Avenue Yacoub el Mansour
Historical Period	Created 1923–1962 by Jacques Majorelle; restored by Yves Saint Laurent from 1980
Opening Hours	Daily 08:00–18:00 (Oct–Apr), 08:00–18:30 (May–Sep)
Entrance Fee	150 MAD (garden); 30 MAD additional for Berber Museum
Nearest Souk	Medina souks (20 min taxi or walk)

Description

Majorelle Garden is one of the most visited sites in all of Morocco. The garden was created by French orientalist painter Jacques Majorelle over four decades, beginning in 1923. He developed a distinctive cobalt blue — Majorelle Blue — that he applied to all structures and pots throughout the garden. After Majorelle's death the garden fell into disrepair until fashion designer Yves Saint Laurent and his partner Pierre Bergé purchased and restored it in 1980. The 2.5-acre garden is filled with exotic species: over 300 varieties of plants from five continents, including towering bamboo groves, cacti from the Americas, and water lilies. The villa houses the Berber Museum, which contains one of the finest collections of Amazigh (Berber) artefacts, jewellery, and textiles in Morocco. The ashes of Yves Saint Laurent are scattered here.

Practical Tips

- Book tickets online in advance — queues can be very long

- The garden is most photogenic in morning light before crowds arrive
- The YSL Museum is directly opposite the garden entrance
- Combine with the Musee Yves Saint Laurent Marrakech next door (70 MAD extra)

RAG Index Tags

Majorelle Garden | Yves Saint Laurent | Jacques Majorelle | Majorelle Blue | Berber Museum | botanical garden | Gueliz

7. Ben Youssef Madrasa يوسف ابن مدرسة

Historic Islamic College · Madrasa · Islamic architecture · Saadian · 14th century

Location	Northern Medina, near the Ben Youssef Mosque
Historical Period	Founded 14th century; rebuilt by Saadian sultan Abdallah al-Ghalib in 1564–65
Opening Hours	Daily 09:00–18:00
Entrance Fee	70 MAD
Nearest Souk	Souk des Bijoutiers (5 min walk south)

Description

The Ben Youssef Madrasa was once the largest Islamic college in North Africa, housing up to 900 students who came from across the Islamic world to study theology, law, and science. Students lived in tiny cells on the upper floors, which visitors can still enter. The madrasa is a masterpiece of Moroccan craftsmanship. The central courtyard contains a large rectangular ablution pool flanked by carved stucco panels, intricate zellij mosaic tilework rising to eye level, and screens of sculpted cedarwood above. Every surface is covered in geometric and calligraphic decoration of extraordinary precision. The madrasa functioned as a college until 1960 and was restored and opened to the public in 1982.

Practical Tips

- One of the finest examples of Moroccan architectural decoration anywhere
- The student cells upstairs give a vivid sense of scholarly life centuries ago
- Allow 45–60 minutes to appreciate the details

RAG Index Tags

Ben Youssef Madrasa | madrasa | Islamic college | zellij | stucco | cedarwood | northern medina

8. Chouara Tannery دباغة الشوارة

Traditional Craft Site · Tannery · Craft · 11th century · Photography

Location	Eastern Medina, near Bab Debbagh
Historical Period	Operating since the 11th century (Almoravid period)
Opening Hours	Best viewed 09:00–12:00 (most activity). Leather shops open daily
Entrance Fee	Free to view from surrounding leather shop balconies (purchases expected but not mandatory)
Nearest Souk	Souk Cherratine (10 min walk west)

Description

The Chouara Tannery is one of the oldest tanneries in the world, operating by the same method for over a thousand years. Hides arrive from slaughterhouses and are first soaked in a mixture of water, quicklime, and pigeon dung to strip the hair and soften the leather — a process that creates a powerful ammonia smell. The hides are then hand-dyed in a series of large stone honeycomb vats using natural pigments: saffron for yellow, indigo for blue, poppy for red, and henna for orange. The resulting tanned leather is used for traditional babouches, bags, and belts sold throughout the medina. The most striking views are from the balconies of surrounding leather shops, which provide a bird's-eye perspective of the coloured vats. Many shops will hand visitors sprigs of mint to mask the smell.

Practical Tips

- Visit in the morning when workers are most active
- Bring or accept mint from the shops to deal with the strong smell
- You are not obligated to buy from the shop that provides balcony access
- Best photography light is in the late morning

RAG Index Tags

Chouara Tannery | *tannery* | *leather* | *babouches* | *Bab Debbagh* | *dyeing vats* | *traditional craft*

9. Mellah — Jewish Quarter الملاح

Historic Neighbourhood · *Historic Quarter* · *Jewish Heritage* · *16th century* · *Architecture*

Location	Southern Medina, adjacent to El Badi Palace and the Royal Palace
Historical Period	Established 1558 under Saadian sultan Abdallah al-Ghalib
Opening Hours	Open neighbourhood — accessible at all hours
Entrance Fee	Free (Lazama Synagogue: small donation requested)
Nearest Souk	Mellah market and spice souk (within the quarter)

Description

The Mellah is Marrakech's historic Jewish quarter, established in 1558 to house the city's growing Jewish population near the royal palace for their protection. At its peak in the early 20th century the Mellah was home to 35,000 Jewish inhabitants; today most have emigrated to Israel, France, or elsewhere. The architecture is distinctive: narrow streets lined with houses featuring characteristic overhanging wooden balconies — a style that allowed neighbours to communicate across the alley. The quarter contains the beautifully restored Lazama Synagogue (17th century), a large Jewish cemetery, and several other historic synagogues in various states of repair. The main street, Rue Talmud Torah, still has gold and silver merchants. The Mellah is less frequented by tourists than the main souks, offering a quieter, more atmospheric exploration.

Practical Tips

- A quieter alternative to the main souks — highly recommended for atmosphere
- The Lazama Synagogue is open to visitors and has been beautifully restored
- The Jewish cemetery on the southern edge is one of the largest in Morocco

RAG Index Tags

Mellah | *Jewish quarter* | *Lazama Synagogue* | *Jewish cemetery* | *overhanging balconies* | *southern medina*

10. Menara Gardens حدائق المنارة

[Historic Royal Garden](#) · [Gardens](#) · [Almohad](#) · [Pavilion](#) · [Atlas Mountains](#)

Location	3 km west of the Medina, near the airport road
Historical Period	Created in the 12th century by the Almohad sultan Abd al-Mumin
Opening Hours	Gardens daily 08:00–19:00; pavilion 09:00–17:00
Entrance Fee	Gardens free; pavilion 10 MAD
Nearest Souk	Medina souks (15 min taxi)

Description

The Menara Gardens are among the oldest functioning royal gardens in Morocco, originally created to supply the city with fruit and timber. The centrepiece is a vast rectangular reservoir (basin) measuring 200 by 190 metres that was built in the 12th century to irrigate the olive orchards surrounding it — thousands of olive trees still stand in the gardens today. A 19th-century green-roofed pavilion (menara) stands on the basin's bank, its reflection perfectly mirrored in the still water. When the conditions are right, the snow-capped Atlas Mountains rise dramatically behind the pavilion — a composition that has become one of the defining images of Marrakech. The gardens are particularly beautiful at golden hour and are a popular destination for local families in the evenings.

Practical Tips

- The classic postcard photograph is taken from the north bank of the basin
- Best visited in winter and spring when the Atlas Mountains are snow-capped
- A calm, local-feeling escape from the intensity of the medina

RAG Index Tags

[Menara Gardens](#) | [menara pavilion](#) | [Atlas Mountains reflection](#) | [olive gardens](#) | [Almohad](#) | [reservoir](#)

11. Agdal Gardens حدائق الأكdal

[Historic Royal Garden](#) · [Royal Gardens](#) · [Almohad](#) · [Khattara](#) · [UNESCO](#)

Location	South of the Royal Palace, southern edge of the Medina
Historical Period	Created 12th century; expanded by Almohad, Saadian, and Alaouite dynasties
Opening Hours	Fridays and Sundays (when the Royal Family is not in residence)
Entrance Fee	Free
Nearest Souk	Mellah market (15 min walk north)

Description

The Agdal Gardens form the largest historic garden in Morocco, covering nearly 400 hectares south of the Royal Palace. The name Agdal derives from the Tamazight (Berber) word for "walled meadow." The gardens were originally created in the 12th century and were subsequently expanded and maintained by the Saadian and Alaouite dynasties. They contain vast orchards of olive, orange, pomegranate, fig, and apricot trees irrigated by a traditional khettara system — an ancient underground canal network that channels water from the Atlas Mountains. The gardens centre on two large basins: the Sahraj el-Hana (Pool of Health) and the Dar el-Hana pavilion. The Agdal

Gardens are listed as part of the UNESCO World Heritage Site of Marrakech. Their austere grandeur is quite different from the manicured Menara Gardens.

Practical Tips

- Only open Fridays and Sundays when the king is not in residence
- The walk along the orchards is serene and photogenic in spring blossom season
- Combine with a visit to the Mellah nearby

RAG Index Tags

Agdal Gardens | royal gardens | khettara | Sahraj el-Hana | orchards | UNESCO | southern medina

12. Dar Si Said Museum دار سي سعيد

Museum of Moroccan Arts · Museum · 19th century · Crafts · Woodwork · Zellij

Location	Southern Medina, Riad Zitoun el-Jedid (near Bahia Palace)
Historical Period	Palace built late 19th century; museum opened 1932
Opening Hours	Wednesday–Monday 09:00–16:30, closed Tuesday
Entrance Fee	20 MAD
Nearest Souk	Souk Cherratine (12 min walk north)

Description

Dar Si Said is a late 19th-century palace turned into one of Morocco's first public museums of traditional crafts and decorative arts. The palace was built by Si Said, the brother of Grand Vizier Ba Ahmed (who built Bahia Palace nearby). The building itself is a refined example of traditional Moroccan domestic architecture with carved cedarwood ceilings, painted rooms, a central courtyard with a marble fountain, and zellige-tiled walls. The collection includes exceptional examples of traditional crafts from across southern Morocco: carved cedarwood panels and furniture, Berber jewellery, High Atlas woven textiles, decorated pottery from Safi and Fes, and leatherwork. A remarkable collection of carved and painted wooden wedding palanquins (amarria) is displayed on the upper floor.

Practical Tips

- Often overlooked by tourists despite being excellent — rarely crowded
- The cedarwood ceilings on the upper floor are extraordinary
- The Berber jewellery collection is one of the finest on public display

RAG Index Tags

Dar Si Said | museum | Moroccan crafts | cedarwood | Berber jewellery | zellij | wedding palanquins

13. Musée de Marrakech متحف مراكش

Museum in a Historic Palace · Museum · Contemporary Art · Palace · 19th century

Location	Northern Medina, Place Ben Youssef, beside Ben Youssef Madrasa
Historical Period	Palace built 1880s; converted to museum 1997
Opening Hours	Daily 09:00–18:30

Entrance Fee	50 MAD (includes Ben Youssef Madrasa with combined ticket)
Nearest Souk	Souk des Bijoutiers (5 min walk south)

Description

The Musée de Marrakech is housed in the late 19th-century Mnebhi Palace, a building that once served as the residence of the powerful Moroccan minister Mehdi Mnebhi and later as the headquarters of the French Protectorate. The palace was meticulously restored by the Omar Benjelloun Foundation and opened as a museum in 1997. The central courtyard — one of the largest in a private riad in Marrakech — is its most striking feature: a vast hammam-domed space hung with an enormous Murano glass chandelier and illuminated by natural light from above. The museum hosts rotating exhibitions of Moroccan contemporary art, calligraphy, photography, and historic objects alongside a permanent collection of traditional artefacts. The combined ticket with the adjacent Ben Youssef Madrasa offers excellent value.

Practical Tips

- Buy the combined ticket with Ben Youssef Madrasa for the best value
- The central courtyard is one of the most beautiful interior spaces in the medina
- The bookshop has a good selection of books on Moroccan art and architecture

RAG Index Tags

Musee de Marrakech | museum | Mnebhi Palace | contemporary art | central courtyard | Ben Youssef | northern medina

14. Musée Yves Saint Laurent Marrakech متحف إيف سان لوران مراكش

Fashion & Design Museum · Fashion Museum · YSL · Contemporary · Design

Location	Gueliz (Ville Nouvelle), opposite Majorelle Garden
Historical Period	Opened October 2017
Opening Hours	Saturday–Thursday 10:00–18:00, closed Friday
Entrance Fee	100 MAD
Nearest Souk	Medina souks (20 min taxi)

Description

The Musée Yves Saint Laurent Marrakech opened in 2017 in a purpose-built, award-winning building designed by French architects Studio KO. The building references traditional Moroccan craftsmanship with a terra-cotta brick facade woven in a pattern inspired by Moroccan textiles. The museum is dedicated to the life and work of fashion designer Yves Saint Laurent, who first visited Marrakech in 1966 and was profoundly influenced by its colours, craftsmanship, and light. Saint Laurent co-owned Majorelle Garden, directly opposite, from 1980 until his death in 2008. The 4,000 sq metre museum contains a permanent collection of around 50 haute couture garments alongside rotating exhibitions of fashion illustration, photography, and decorative objects. The cafe and bookshop are among the best in Marrakech.

Practical Tips

- Book tickets online — it sells out on weekends
- Combine with Majorelle Garden directly opposite
- The museum cafe terrace is excellent for lunch
- Photography is not permitted inside the galleries

RAG Index Tags

Musee YSL | Yves Saint Laurent museum | fashion | Gueliz | Studio KO | haute couture | Majorelle

15. Medina Ramparts & City Gates أسوار مراكش وأبوابها

Historic Fortifications · Ramparts · Almoravid · City Walls · Gates · Architecture

Location	Encircling the entire Medina (19 km perimeter)
Historical Period	Built from 1126–1127 AD under Almoravid sultan Ali ibn Yusuf
Opening Hours	Exterior accessible 24 hours
Entrance Fee	Free
Nearest Souk	Vary by gate — see individual gates below

Description

Marrakech's 19-kilometre circuit of ramparts is one of the best-preserved sets of medieval city walls in the world. Built in pisé (rammed red earth mixed with lime), the walls reach up to 9 metres in height and are punctuated by 200 towers. They are the source of Marrakech's nickname: "the Red City." The most important of the original fourteen city gates are: Bab Agnaou, the most ornate surviving Almohad gate with deeply carved geometric stonework, which leads to the Kasbah district; Bab el-Khemis (Gate of Thursday) in the north, outside which a famous flea and antique market is held on Thursdays and Sundays; Bab Doukkala in the northwest, near the main bus station; and Bab Debbagh in the east, adjacent to the tanneries. The walls are most atmospheric when viewed from outside at dusk, when they glow golden-red.

Practical Tips

- A horse-drawn calèche ride along the exterior of the walls at sunset is a classic Marrakech experience (negotiate the price beforehand: around 150–200 MAD for 30 min)
- Bab Agnaou is the most photographed gate — the Saadian Tombs are just inside
- The Thursday flea market at Bab el-Khemis is excellent for antiques and bric-a-brac

RAG Index Tags

ramparts | city walls | Bab Agnaou | Bab el-Khemis | Bab Doukkala | Bab Debbagh | medina gates | pise walls

16. Souks of Marrakech أسواق مراكش

Historic Market District · Souks · Shopping · Crafts · Medieval · Trade

Location	North of Jemaa el-Fna, inside the Medina
Historical Period	System of trade-specific souks established from the 12th century onward
Opening Hours	Most shops 09:00–20:00; Fridays more limited hours
Entrance Fee	Free
Nearest Souk	The souks ARE the destination

Description

The souks of Marrakech form one of the largest and best-preserved medieval market complexes in the world. Unlike Western markets, the Marrakech souks are organised by trade in a system largely

unchanged since the medieval period. Entering from Jemaa el-Fna, the main artery is Souk Semmarine (bags, shoes, pottery, textiles). Branching from it: Souk Smata (babouches — leather slippers in every colour, 80–150 MAD); Souk Zrabi (handwoven Berber carpets, 800–5,000+ MAD); Souk Cherratine (leather bags and belts); Rahba Kedima, the "Spice Square" (cumin, saffron, ras el hanout, medicinal herbs, rosewater, 30–80 MAD per 100g); Souk Haddadine where metalworkers hammer brass lanterns in atmospheric workshops; Souk des Bijoutiers (silver and Berber jewellery, amber beads); Souk El Attarine (argan oil, orange flower water, perfumes, 150–300 MAD); and Souk Chouari (wood, baskets, and carpentry). The souks are also home to fondouks — medieval caravanserai inns arranged around central courtyards that were once accommodation for travelling merchants and their animals.

Practical Tips

- Start from Jemaa el-Fna and walk north — you cannot get lost for long
- Bargaining is expected: open at 30–40% of the asking price and work up
- The best craftwork (not tourist souvenirs) is found deeper in the souks away from the main artery
- Fondouks can be entered freely — look for the arched doorways off the main passages

RAG Index Tags

souks | *Souk Semmarine* | *Souk Smata* | *Souk Zrabi* | *Rahba Kedima* | *Souk Haddadine* | *Souk El Attarine* | *argan oil* | *babouches* | *carpet* | *spices*

17. Mouassine Neighbourhood & Fountain حي المواسين

Historic Neighbourhood · *Neighbourhood* · *Fountain* · *Saadian* · *Riad Hotels* · *Artisan*

Location	Western Medina, between the souks and the Ben Youssef Mosque
Historical Period	Mouassine Mosque and fountain built 1562–1573 under Saadian dynasty
Opening Hours	Open neighbourhood. Mouassine Fountain: exterior visible 24h
Entrance Fee	Free
Nearest Souk	Souk El Attarine (5 min walk east)

Description

The Mouassine neighbourhood is one of the most atmospheric and characterful quarters of the medina, and increasingly favoured by discerning travellers for its concentration of upscale riads, boutique concept stores, and artisan workshops. The centrepiece is the Mouassine Fountain (Siqaya Mouassine), a 16th-century Saadian public fountain remarkable for its scale: it has three separate basins — one for humans, one for horses, and one for donkeys — with an ornately carved cedar canopy above. Adjacent is the Mouassine Mosque (closed to non-Muslims). The streets around it are lined with some of the finest fabric merchants, antique dealers, and concept boutiques in Marrakech. The neighbourhood is also home to the Secret Garden (Jardin Secret, see entry).

Practical Tips

- The neighbourhood around Mouassine is the best area for high-quality craft shopping away from the tourist-heavy main souks
- The Mouassine fountain is often missed by tourists — look for the ornate cedar canopy
- Several excellent restaurant terraces have views over the rooftops from here

RAG Index Tags

Mouassine | *Mouassine Fountain* | *Siqaya* | *Saadian fountain* | *western medina* | *riads* | *concept stores*

18. Le Jardin Secret (The Secret Garden) الحديقة السرية

Historic Riad Garden · Garden · Saadian · Architecture · Rooftop Views

Location	Mouassine neighbourhood, Rue Mouassine, Northern Medina
Historical Period	Original riad 16th century (Saadian); restored and opened to public 2016
Opening Hours	Daily 09:30–19:00 (summer), 09:30–17:30 (winter)
Entrance Fee	50 MAD
Nearest Souk	Souk El Attarine (5 min walk)

Description

The Jardin Secret (Secret Garden) is a restored 16th-century Saadian-era riad comprising two contrasting gardens: an "exotic garden" planted with tropical species from across the world, and an "Islamic garden" of geometric precision with citrus trees, roses, herbs, and fountains following the traditional char-bagh (four-quadrant paradise garden) layout. The riad was restored between 2008 and 2016 to its historic layout. The restoration team discovered an original khettara (underground irrigation canal) beneath the garden that still functions today. A tower at the centre of the riad offers 360-degree views over the rooftops and minarets of the medina and, on clear days, to the Atlas Mountains. The garden's cafe is a peaceful spot for mint tea.

Practical Tips

- The rooftop tower gives the best 360-degree views of the medina rooftops
- Much less crowded than Majorelle — a better choice if you want tranquillity
- The garden cafe is excellent for a mid-morning break

RAG Index Tags

Jardin Secret | Secret Garden | Islamic garden | exotic garden | char-bagh | rooftop views | Mouassine | khettara

19. Palais Badii / Place des Ferblantiers ساحة الحدادين

Public Square & Craft Market · Square · Lanterns · Metalwork · Local Life

Location	Adjacent to El Badi Palace, southern Medina
Historical Period	Traditional market area; Place des Ferblantiers developed in the 20th century
Opening Hours	Market stalls open daily 09:00–20:00
Entrance Fee	Free
Nearest Souk	Mellah market (2 min walk)

Description

Place des Ferblantiers — the Square of the Tinsmiths — sits at the edge of El Badi Palace adjacent to the Mellah. It is the centre of Marrakech's metalworking and lantern trade. The square is lined with workshops and stalls where artisans cut, pierce, and assemble traditional Moroccan lanterns (fanous) in brass, copper, and tin, as well as star-shaped table lanterns and ornate light fixtures. The metalwork produced here is the source of the lanterns found in riads and hotels throughout Morocco. The square has a more authentically workaday atmosphere than the tourist-facing sections of the souks, and the prices tend to be lower. In the evenings local families gather around the central trees, and the square transitions into an informal social space.

Practical Tips

- One of the best places to buy authentic Moroccan lanterns at reasonable prices
- Watch craftsmen at work in the surrounding workshops
- A pleasant evening stroll from El Badi Palace and the Saadian Tombs

RAG Index Tags

Place des Ferblantiers | tinsmiths | lanterns | metalwork | Badi Palace | Mellah | fanous

20. Gueliz — The Ville Nouvelle كـلـيـز

Modern Neighbourhood · Ville Nouvelle · Art Deco · Cafes · French Colonial · Restaurants

Location	West of the Medina, centred on Avenue Mohammed V
Historical Period	Built from 1913 onward under the French Protectorate
Opening Hours	Open neighbourhood
Entrance Fee	Free
Nearest Souk	Medina souks (20 min walk or taxi)

Description

Gueliz is the Ville Nouvelle (New Town) of Marrakech, built by the French colonial administration from 1913 to house European settlers and administrative buildings outside the historic medina. The neighbourhood is centred on the wide, tree-lined Avenue Mohammed V, flanked by Art Deco and Mauresque (neo-Moorish) architecture from the 1920s–1940s. Today Gueliz is the commercial, dining, and nightlife hub of modern Marrakech, with the city's best restaurants, wine bars, galleries, international boutiques, and art spaces concentrated here. The Central Market (Marché Central) on Rue ibn Toumert sells fresh produce, spices, and flowers. Gueliz also contains several important cultural institutions, including the Musée Yves Saint Laurent and the Majorelle Garden.

Practical Tips

- Head here for a break from the intensity of the medina
- The best international restaurants and rooftop bars are in Gueliz
- The Marché Central is a great place to buy spices and local produce at fixed prices
- Avenue Mohammed V is pleasant for an evening stroll

RAG Index Tags

Gueliz | Ville Nouvelle | Avenue Mohammed V | Art Deco | French colonial | restaurants | nightlife | Marrakech modern

RAG Usage Notes

Each place entry in this document corresponds to one RAG chunk. When generating embeddings, use the full Description field as the primary embedding text, supplemented by the RAG Index Tags line. The info table fields (location, period, opening hours, entrance fee) should be concatenated as metadata.

The RAG Index Tags at the end of each entry contain common search variants, Arabic transliterations, and topic keywords to improve retrieval recall for queries phrased in different ways.

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